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Sports Desk

By JOE DIETZ

A mighty man is Willie Mays

"Did you see Willie Mays playing the infield during batting practice?" the young man of the house wanted to know on the way home from a Giants-Phils game the other night.

"Willie was playing to the right of second base and nailed a hot grounder backhand and in the same motion flipped it to the short-stop. Never saw anything so pretty in my life. It bet that guy could play any position—maybe even catch and pitch."

This is the hold Mays has on the fans. You can feel it when he steps into the batting cage. Every ball he hits has drama and the fans respond much as they do to a gorgeous float in the Tournament of Roses parade.

You can feel it too, when Willie walks with second base open. Will he steal? And when? Even when he does something foolish like trying to steal third without a good jump, Mays does it with a flair that even the enemy fans kinda regret he didn't make it.

Never breaks stride

And what is prettier than Mays going from first to third on a single, whipping his legs around in half circles in that pigeon-toed stride of his. You'll never see him slow up or break his stride to touch second. He hits the bag like a broad jumper hits the board at takeoff—in perfect stride.

"I don't know how he does it," says manager Bill Rigney, "but I've never seen him miss the inside of the bag going from first to third."

Maybe other players like DiMaggio were as good or better center fielders than Mays. But none could make playing center as exciting to the fans as Willie. None of them used his glove as a basket the way Willie does.

Like Musial, Stengel

Confidentially, though, even with his great skills, Mays wouldn't be the guy he is if he didn't lose his cap every time he makes a mad dash for a ball or a base. It's things like that which endear this boy to the fans—like Musial's smile and Casey Stengel's double-talk. It's the extra dividend the public seems to want from every ballplayer and rarely gets.

Diamond leftovers: Chub Feeney, Giants veep, reports that six persons have died in Candlestick Park since it opened. "They were all heart cases," he said. "Only two of them died in the park itself; the others died on a slight incline that leads up to the stadium" . . . Candlestick engineers still can't get those steam-heated seats to work properly. Lots of bugs developed, but officials feel value of this new wrinkle has been over-emphasized.

Shouldn't the Yankees call the Athletics' home town "Cousin City" instead of Kansas City?

Giants may call Wilson

Seems now that Jimmy Davenport, Giants' third baseman does have an ulcer. Your agent must have been listening to the wrong diagnostician . . . Rigney is thinking about bringing up Neil Wilson from the minors to help out in the catching department. Rig doesn't feel comfortable with only two catchers.

When a certain big league manager blew his stack the other night, he looked like he had just swallowed Bill Veck's scoreboard.

Maybe it's cruel to joke about a ballplayers misfortunes on the field, but somebody did say, after Yankee first baseman Bill Skowron dropped three fouls in four games that Stengel should switch him to left field . . . Few pitchers in the majors appear to put so much into their pitches as Sad Sam Jones. Seems to have every muscle in his body behind the throw.

Big Frank Howard the Dodger fence buster, won't get many baseballs dirty throwing from right field to home plate. His throws come in on a sizzling line. Only trouble is they may wind up ten yards wide of the plate . . . Ken Silvestri, former Yankee catcher now coaching the Phils, says hello to everybody up this way. Ken rooms with former Giant Andy Cohen, fellow coach and only undefeated manager in the majors. Andy beat Milwaukee opening night while awaiting the arrival of the new manager, Gene Mauch, from the minors . . . Mauch, incidentally, seems to have the Philly disciplinary problem licked. Now if he could get them to play ball.